Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

- Document version: 1.0.0-beta, April-2026
- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1.
- Distributed at: https://github.com/wrwetzel/Helix-Cheat-Sheet
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1.1 Definitions

- **file** - the actual data on storage device
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor, not just the selection
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping

1.2 Typographic Conventions

- **`word`** - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- **`WORD`** - whitespace-delimited
- **`Ctrl-c`** - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- **`Alt-c`** - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- **`␣c`** is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars **`<regex>`**, **`<file>`** and **`<ch>`** represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- **`␣`**, **`<minus>`**, and **`<under>`** used for clarity. **`<enter>`**, **`<del>`**, **`<bksp>`**, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.3 Launching

- **`helix`**
- **`helix`** `<file>`
- **`helix`** `<file1> <file2> … <filen>`
- **`helix`** `–help`
- **`hx`** `in some distributions or by alias`

1.4 Basics

Editing paradigm: select first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

1.4.1 Example

```
v3wd
          v – enter select mode
          3 – select 3
          w – words
          d – delete
```

1.4.2 Samples

```
         wd – delete word
         xc – change line
         %y – yank entire file
```

1.5 Modes

As used in Helix documentation.

```
          : – command
          i – insert
          v – select or extend
          z – view - change view preserving selection
          g – goto
          m – match
     Ctrl-w – window
          ␣ – space
       [, ] – unimpaired
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Essentials

```
      u / U – undo / redo change in linear history
   Alt-u / – move backward / forward in tree history
     Alt-U
:ear / :lat – move backward / forward in history by
              step count or time span (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
 <nn><cmd> – repeat <cmd> <nn> times
       Esc – return to normal mode
```

2.1.1 Quit

Add **!** suffix to force operation.

```
        :wq – write current buffer and quit
  :wq <file> – write current buffer to <file> and quit
       :wqa – write all buffer(s) and quit
         :q – quit current buffer, exits if last
```

2.1.2 Files

```
   :o <file> – open <file> in new buffer
   :w <file> – write current buffer to <file>

  :hs <file> – open/create <file> in new horizontal split
  :vs <file> – open/create <file> in new vertical split
         ␣wf – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in
               horizontal split
         ␣wF – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in
               vertical split
          gf – open/create file(s) under selection, open url
               under selection.

          ␣f – open file picker at LSP workspace root
          ␣F – open file picker at current working
               directory
          ␣g – open changed file picker
```

2.1.2.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

```
    <enter> – open selected in current view
     Ctrl-s – open selected in new horizontal split
     Ctrl-v – open selected in new vertical split
```

2.1.3 Buffers

Add **!** suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

```
         :n – create new scratch buffer
        :bc – close current buffer
       :bca – close all buffers
       :bco – close all but current buffer
        :bn – next buffer
         ␣b – open buffer picker

        ga – go to last accessed/alternate buffer
        gm – go to last modified/alternate buffer
        gn – go to next buffer
        gp – go to previous buffer
```

2.1.4 Views

Ctrl-w and ␣w are synonymous.

```
  ␣ws / ␣wv  – split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
 ␣wns / ␣wnv – split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
        ␣wq – close current split
        ␣wo – close all but current split
        ␣ww – next split

  ␣wh/j/k/l – move to buffer left / up / down / right
  ␣wH/J/K/L – swap split with buffer on left / up / down /
              right
        ␣wt – transpose split
```

2.1.4.1 View Movement

Commands shown with **z** prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

```
         Z – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc

   zz, zc – align to center
        zt – align to top
        zb – align to bottom
        zm – align to middle horizontally
        zj – scroll down
        zk – scroll up
```

2.1.5 Help

```
     :tutor – open tutorial
         ␣? – open command palette
```

2.2 Movement

2.2.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

```
      h/j/k/l – left / up / down / right
     gh, g|   – beginning of line
     <nn>g|   – column <nn>
         gl   – end of line
         gg   – top of file
<nn>G, g<nn>g – line <nn>
         ge   – bottom of file
         gw   – two-char labels on words, label to go to
                word

         g.   – to last modification in current file
         gj   – down textual line
         gk   – up textual line

         gs   – first non-white-space char
         gt   – top of screen
         gc   – middle of screen
         gb   – bottom of screen
```

2.2.2 By Language Server Protocol - Semantics

Requires LSP support.

```
gd – go to definition
gy – go to type definition
gr – go to references
gi – go to implementation

]d – next diagnostic
[d – prior diagnostic
]D – last diagnostic
[D – first diagnostic
```

2.2.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
]f, [f – to next, prior function
]t, [t – to next, prior type definition
]T, [T – to next, prior test
]a, [a – to next, prior arg
]c, [c – to next, prior comment
]g, [g – to next, prior change
]G, [G – to last, first change

Alt-e – move to end of parent node in syntax tree
Alt-b – move to start of parent node in syntax tree
```

2.2.4 By Page

```
Ctrl-b – page up
Ctrl-f – page down
Ctrl-u – half page up
Ctrl-d – half page down
```

2.3 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between anchor and cursor
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.3.1 Operations

```
%      – select whole file
Alt-;  – swap anchor and cursor
Alt-:  – selection to normal direction (cursor at
         end)
Alt-o  – expand selection syntax-aware
Alt-i  – shrink selection
;      – collapse selection(s) to cursor(s)
```

2.3.2 By TextObjects

```
ma<ch> / mi<ch> – match around / inside the object
                  indicated by <ch> below:

w / W – word / WORD
    p – paragraph
(, [, ', etc.– specified surround pairs
    m –  closest surround pair
    f – function
    t – type or class
    a – argument/parameter
    c – comment
    T – test
    g – change git hunk
```

2.3.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
w / W – to start of next word / WORD
e / E – to end of current word / WORD
b / B – to start of current word / WORD
    x – current line, extend by line
    X – extend to line
Alt-x – shrink to line bounds
   ]p – to next paragraph
   [p – to prior paragraph
```

2.3.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
Alt-o – expand selection to parent syntax node
Alt-i – shrink syntax tree object selection
Alt-p – select previous sibling node in syntax tree
Alt-n – select next sibling node in syntax tree
Alt-a – select all sibling nodes in syntax tree
Alt-I – select all children nodes in syntax tree
```

2.3.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
f<ch>, F<ch> – to <ch> inclusive (find)
t<ch>, T<ch> – to <ch> exclusive (till)
      Alt-.  – repeat last find / till
```

2.4 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

```
     v – toggle select mode
   Esc – return to normal
     ) – cycle primary selection forward
     ( – cycle primary selection backward
Alt-,  – remove primary selection
```

2.5 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one is *primary*.

2.5.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

```
s<regex> – matches become selections
       S – split on match
    Alt-s – split on newlines
C, Alt-C – add selection below, above
```

2.5.2 Operations

```
           & – align on primary cursor
Alt-<minus> – merge selections
Alt-<under> – merge consecutive selections
           , – remove all except primary selection
      Alt-,  – remove primary selection
       ( / ) – rotate primary backwards / forwards
     Alt-( / – rotate content backward / forward
       Alt-)
           K – keep selections matching the regex
       Alt-K – remove selections matching the regex
```

2.6 Alter Buffer Content

2.6.1 Insert

```
       i – before selection
       a – after selection
       I – at start of line
       A – at end of line
       o – add line and insert below cursor
       O – add line and insert above cursor
     Esc – end insert (return to normal)
       . – repeat last insert
```

2.6.2 Add

```
      ]␣ – newline below
      [␣ – newline above
  ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.3 Delete

```
       d – selection -> yank buf, delete selection
   Alt-d – delete, no save
  md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.4 Change

```
       c – selection -> yank buf, change selection
   Alt-c – change, no save
       = – format by LSP
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.6.5 Indent Lines

```
       > – Indent line(s) containing selection
       < – Undent line(s) containing selection
```

2.6.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

```
       ~ – change case
       ` – set lowercase
    Alt-` – set uppercase
```

2.6.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

```
  ␣c, Ctrl-c – Toggle comment
         ␣C – Toggle block comment
     ␣Alt-C – Toggle line comment
```

2.6.8 Increment / Decrement

```
   Ctrl-a – increment the selected number
   Ctrl-x – decrement the selected number
```

2.6.9 Miscellaneous

```
       J – join lines in a selection
   Alt-J – join lines inside selection and select the
           inserted space
  <under> – trim whitespace from selection
```

2.7 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
       y – selection -> yank buf
       p – paste yank buf after the cursor
       P – paste yank buf before the cursor
      ␣y – yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
      ␣Y – yank main selection -> system clipboard
  ␣p / ␣P – paste clipboard after / before selections(s)
      ␣R – replace selection(s) with clipboard
   r<ch> – replace selection with <ch>
       R – replace selection with yank buf
       " – select register to yank to or paste from
```

2.8 Search

```
  /<regex> – search forward for regex
  ?<regex> – search backward for regex
     n, N – next, previous match
        * – search for current selection, respect word
            boundaries
    Alt-* – search for current selection
```

2.9 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
   "<ch> – change to reg <ch>
  "<ch>y – yank into reg <ch>
  "<ch>p – paste from reg <ch>
  "<ch>R – replace with reg <ch>
```

2.10 Macros

```
"<ch>Q – toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
"<ch>q – play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.11 Jumplists

```
Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist
Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist
Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist
␣j – open jumplist picker
```

2.12 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
mm – go to matching delim
mi<ch> – match inside delim <ch>
ma<ch> – match around delim <ch>
ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.13 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
| – replace selection(s) with output
Alt-| – ignore output
! – insert output before each selection(s)
Alt-! – append output after each selection(s)
$ – keep selection(s) where command
    returned 0
```

2.14 Approaching an IDE

```
␣G – debug - experimental
␣k – show documentation for item under
     cursor
␣s – open document symbol picker
␣S – open workspace symbol picker
␣d – open document diagnostics picker
␣D – open workspace diagnostics picker
␣r – rename symbol
␣a – apply code action
␣h – select symbol references for symbol under
     cursor
```

2.15 Editor Configuration

```
:config-open – open the config file
:config-open-workspace – open the workspace config
                         file
:config-reload – reload the config file
```

2.16 Miscellaneous

```
␣' – open last picker
␣/ – open global search in workspace folder
     picker
```

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

```
                Ctrl-s – commit undo checkpoint
                Ctrl-x – autocomplete
                Ctrl-r – insert a register content
   Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp> – delete previous word
     Alt-d, Alt-<del> – delete next word
                Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
                Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
      Ctrl-h, <bksp>,– delete previous char
         Shift-<bksp>
       Ctrl-d, <del> – delete next char
     Ctrl-j, <enter> – insert new line
  <Up> <Down> <Left> – usual meaning but
    <Right> <PageUp>   discouraged
   <PageDown> <Home>
               <End>
```

3.2 Command Line Editing

```
           Esc, Ctrl-c – close prompt
               <enter> – open selected
                 <tab> – select next completion item
             <backtab> – select previous completion
                         item
                 Alt-b – backward a word
                Ctrl-b – backward a char
                 Alt-f – forward a word
                Ctrl-f – forward a char
                Ctrl-e – to prompt end
                Ctrl-a – to prompt start
  Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp> – delete previous word
    Alt-d, Ctrl-<del> – delete next word
                Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
                Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
       <bksp>, Ctrl-h – delete previous char
        <del>, Ctrl-d – delete next char
                Ctrl-s – insert a word under doc
                         cursor (may be changed to
                         Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
                Ctrl-p – select previous history
                Ctrl-n – select next history
                Ctrl-r – insert the content of the
                         register selected by following
                         input char
```

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

```
   Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p,– previous entry
                   <Up>
 <tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down> – next entry
                 <Home> – to first entry
                  <End> – to last entry
      Ctrl-u, <PageUp> – page up
    Ctrl-d, <PageDown> – page down
               <enter> – open selected
           Alt-<enter> – open selected in the
                         background without closing
                         the picker
                 Ctrl-s – open horizontally
                 Ctrl-v – open vertically
                 Ctrl-t – toggle preview
            Esc, Ctrl-c – close picker
```

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

```
      Ctrl-u – scroll up
      Ctrl-d – scroll down
```

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

```
   Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p – previous entry
         Tab, Ctrl-n – next entry
             <enter> – close menu and accept
                       completion
              Ctrl-c – close menu and reject
                       completion
```

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

```
      Alt-p – previous signature
      Alt-n – next signature
```

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- **Ctrl-c** – close picker **(3.3)**
- **Ctrl-c** – close prompt **(3.2)**
- **Ctrl-d** – delete next char **(3.1)**
- **Ctrl-d** – delete next char **(3.2)**
- **Ctrl-d** – half page down **(2.2.4)**
- **Ctrl-d** – page down **(3.3)**
- **Ctrl-d** – scroll down **(3.4)**
- **Ctrl-e** – to prompt end **(3.2)**
- **Ctrl-f** – forward a char **(3.2)**
- **Ctrl-f** – page down **(2.2.4)**
- **Ctrl-h** – delete previous char **(3.1)**
- **Ctrl-h** – delete previous char **(3.2)**
- **Ctrl-i** – move forward in jumplist **(2.11)**
- **Ctrl-j** – insert new line **(3.1)**
- **Ctrl-k** – delete to end of line **(3.1)**
- **Ctrl-k** – delete to end of line **(3.2)**
- **Ctrl-n** – next entry **(3.3)**
- **Ctrl-n** – next entry **(3.5)**
- **Ctrl-n** – select next history **(3.2)**
- **Ctrl-o** – move backwards in jumplist **(2.11)**
- **Ctrl-p** – previous entry **(3.3)**
- **Ctrl-p** – previous entry **(3.5)**
- **Ctrl-p** – select previous history **(3.2)**
- **Ctrl-r** – insert a register content **(3.1)**
- **Ctrl-r** – insert the content of the register selected by following input char **(3.2)**
- **Ctrl-s** – commit undo checkpoint **(3.1)**
- **Ctrl-s** – insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later) **(3.2)**
- **Ctrl-s** – open horizontally **(3.3)**
- **Ctrl-s** – open selected in new horizontal split **(2.1.2.1)**
- **Ctrl-s** – save current position to jumplist **(2.11)**
- **Ctrl-t** – toggle preview **(3.3)**
- **Ctrl-u** – delete to start of line **(3.1)**
- **Ctrl-u** – delete to start of line **(3.2)**
- **Ctrl-u** – half page up **(2.2.4)**
- **Ctrl-u** – page up **(3.3)**
- **Ctrl-u** – scroll up **(3.4)**
- **Ctrl-v** – open selected in new vertical split **(2.1.2.1)**
- **Ctrl-v** – open vertically **(3.3)**
- **Ctrl-w** – delete previous word **(3.1)**
- **Ctrl-w** – delete previous word **(3.2)**
- **Ctrl-x** – autocomplete **(3.1)**
- **Ctrl-x** – decrement the selected number **(2.6.8)**
- **Esc** – close picker **(3.3)**
- **Esc** – close prompt **(3.2)**
- **Esc** – end insert (return to normal) **(2.6.1)**
- **Esc** – return to normal **(2.4)**
- **Esc** – return to normal mode **(2.1)**
- **F<ch>** – to <ch> inclusive (find) **(2.3.5)**
- **I** – at start of line **(2.6.1)**
- **J** – join lines in a selection **(2.6.9)**
- **K** – keep selections matching the regex **(2.5.2)**
- **N** – next, previous match **(2.8)**
- **O** – add line and insert above cursor **(2.6.1)**
- **P** – paste yank buf before the cursor **(2.7)**
- **R** – replace selection with yank buf **(2.7)**
- **S** – split on match **(2.5.1)**
- **Shift-<bksp>** – delete previous char **(3.1)**
- **Shift-<tab>** – previous entry **(3.3)**
- **Shift-Tab** – previous entry **(3.5)**
- **T** – test **(2.3.2)**
- **T<ch>** – to <ch> exclusive (till) **(2.3.5)**
- **Tab** – next entry **(3.5)**
- **X** – extend to line **(2.3.3)**
- **Z** – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc **(2.1.4.1)**
- **[␣** – newline above **(2.6.2)**
- **[** – specified surround pairs **(2.3.2)**
- **[D** – first diagnostic **(2.2.2)**
- **[G** – to last, first change **(2.2.3)**
- **[T** – to next, prior test **(2.2.3)**
- **[a** – to next, prior arg **(2.2.3)**
- **[c** – to next, prior comment **(2.2.3)**
- **[d** – prior diagnostic **(2.2.2)**
- **[f** – to next, prior function **(2.2.3)**
- **[g** – to next, prior change **(2.2.3)**
- **[p** – to prior paragraph **(2.3.3)**
- **[t** – to next, prior type definition **(2.2.3)**
- **]␣** – newline below **(2.6.2)**
- **]D** – last diagnostic **(2.2.2)**

- `]G` – to last, first change **(2.2.3)**
- `]T` – to next, prior test **(2.2.3)**
- `]a` – to next, prior arg **(2.2.3)**
- `]c` – to next, prior comment **(2.2.3)**
- `]d` – next diagnostic **(2.2.2)**
- `]f` – to next, prior function **(2.2.3)**
- `]g` – to next, prior change **(2.2.3)**
- `]p` – to next paragraph **(2.3.3)**
- `]t` – to next, prior type definition **(2.2.3)**
- `` ` `` – set lowercase **(2.6.6)**
- `a` – after selection **(2.6.1)**
- `a` – argument/parameter **(2.3.2)**
- `b / B` – to start of current word / WORD **(2.3.3)**
- `c` – comment **(2.3.2)**
- `c` – selection -> yank buf, change selection **(2.6.4)**
- `d` – selection -> yank buf, delete selection **(2.6.3)**
- `e / E` – to end of current word / WORD **(2.3.3)**
- `etc.` – specified surround pairs **(2.3.2)**
- `f` – function **(2.3.2)**
- `f<ch>` – to <ch> inclusive (find) **(2.3.5)**
- `g` – change git hunk **(2.3.2)**
- `g.` – to last modification in current file **(2.2.1)**
- `g<nn>g` – line <nn> **(2.2.1)**
- `ga` – go to last accessed/alternate buffer **(2.1.3)**
- `gb` – bottom of screen **(2.2.1)**
- `gc` – middle of screen **(2.2.1)**
- `gd` – go to definition **(2.2.2)**
- `ge` – bottom of file **(2.2.1)**
- `gf` – open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection. **(2.1.2)**
- `gg` – top of file **(2.2.1)**
- `gh` – beginning of line **(2.2.1)**
- `gi` – go to implementation **(2.2.2)**
- `gj` – down textual line **(2.2.1)**
- `gk` – up textual line **(2.2.1)**
- `gl` – end of line **(2.2.1)**
- `gm` – go to last modified/alternate buffer **(2.1.3)**
- `gn` – go to next buffer **(2.1.3)**
- `gp` – go to previous buffer **(2.1.3)**
- `gr` – go to references **(2.2.2)**
- `gs` – first non-white-space char **(2.2.1)**
- `gt` – top of screen **(2.2.1)**
- `gw` – two-char labels on words, label to go to word **(2.2.1)**
- `gy` – go to type definition **(2.2.2)**
- `g|` – beginning of line **(2.2.1)**
- `h/j/k/l` – left / up / down / right **(2.2.1)**
- `i` – before selection **(2.6.1)**
- `m` – closest surround pair **(2.3.2)**
- `ma<ch>` – match around delim <ch> **(2.12)**
- `ma<ch> / mi<ch>` – match around / inside the object indicated by <ch> below: **(2.3.2)**
- `md<ch>` – delete delim <ch> around selection **(2.12)**
- `md<ch>` – delete delim <ch> around selection **(2.6.3)**
- `mi<ch>` – match inside delim <ch> **(2.12)**
- `mm` – go to matching delim **(2.12)**
- `mr<ch1><ch2>` – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2> **(2.12)**
- `mr<ch1><ch2>` – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2> **(2.6.4)**
- `ms<ch>` – add delim <ch> around selection **(2.12)**
- `ms<ch>` – add delim <ch> around selection **(2.6.2)**
- `n` – next, previous match **(2.8)**
- `o` – add line and insert below cursor **(2.6.1)**
- `p` – paragraph **(2.3.2)**
- `p` – paste yank buf after the cursor **(2.7)**
- `r<ch>` – replace selection with <ch> **(2.7)**
- `s<regex>` – matches become selections **(2.5.1)**
- `t` – type or class **(2.3.2)**
- `t<ch>` – to <ch> exclusive (till) **(2.3.5)**

- `u / U` – undo / redo change in linear history **(2.1)**
- `v` – toggle select mode **(2.4)**
- `w / W` – to start of next word / WORD **(2.3.3)**
- `w / W` – word / WORD **(2.3.2)**
- `x` – current line, extend by line **(2.3.3)**
- `y` – selection -> yank buf **(2.7)**
- `zb` – align to bottom **(2.1.4.1)**
- `zc` – align to center **(2.1.4.1)**
- `zj` – scroll down **(2.1.4.1)**
- `zk` – scroll up **(2.1.4.1)**
- `zm` – align to middle horizontally **(2.1.4.1)**
- `zt` – align to top **(2.1.4.1)**
- `zz` – align to center **(2.1.4.1)**
- `|` – replace selection(s) with output **(2.13)**
- `~` – change case **(2.6.6)**